

GLOBAL ECONOMICS ANALYST

Disentangling Tech Hiring Headwinds: Higher Rates, Overhiring, and AI

- Three labor market headwinds—a hawkish Fed pivot that slowed growth and raised rates, AI efficiency gains, and a correction for pandemic-era overhiring—have plausibly contributed to a weaker tech labor market since 2022. Disentangling the role of each is complicated, and some commentators have suggested that companies are “AI-washing” layoffs by falsely attributing them to AI efficiencies. In this *Global Economics Analyst*, we leverage detailed company/occupation-level employment data to quantify the contribution of each headwind since 2022.
- First, we find little evidence that higher interest rates have driven the slowdown in tech hiring. Hiring trends are virtually identical across tech companies that were more and less exposed to higher rates.
- Second, we find that AI has slowed hiring, but its impact is small. Differences in occupational AI exposure explain around ½pp of the slowdown in annual tech employment growth since 2022. We also find that AI-layoff announcements appear credible, as companies that announced AI-related layoffs lowered headcount in AI-related occupations more than companies that cited other reasons for layoffs.
- Third, we find stronger evidence that hiring has underperformed among companies that overhired between 2020-2022. Statistical estimates that account for both company and occupational hiring trends suggest that headcount normalization can explain up to 2pp of the slowdown in annual tech employment growth since 2022.
- The main caveat to our results is that they can only explain around half of the 5pp/year slowdown in tech hiring (vs. trend) since 2022. But our results imply that both AI and post-pandemic headcount normalizations have contributed to the recent tech-sector hiring slowdown, with headcount normalization roughly 3-4 times as important. These relative rankings are generally consistent with company commentary on the role of AI in tech sector layoffs, suggesting AI-washing is not a widespread issue.

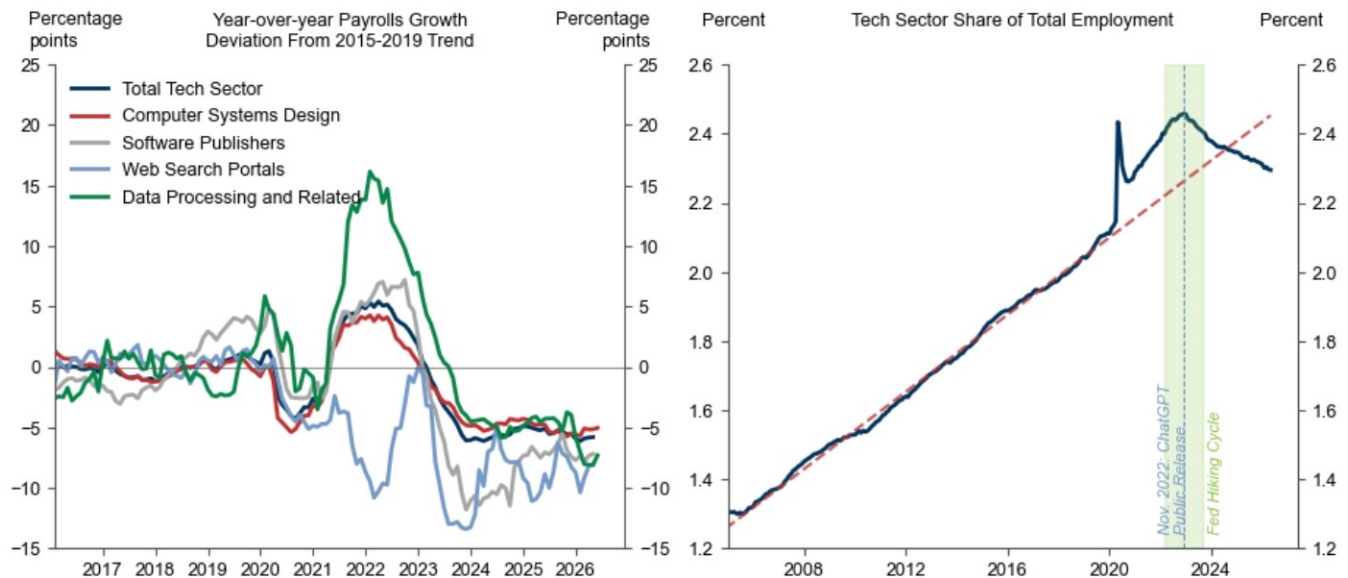
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After hiring surged during the pandemic, the tech-sector labor market has weakened significantly since late 2022, with job growth in several subsectors underperforming its long-run trend by around 5pp. As a result, the tech sector's share of overall employment has fallen below its long-run trend ([Exhibit 1](#)).

Exhibit 1: Tech Sector Employment Has Underperformed Since 2022



Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Three labor market dynamics—a hawkish Fed pivot that slowed growth and raised rates, AI efficiency gains, and a correction for pandemic overhiring—have plausibly contributed to the tech sector's labor market pullback since late 2022. But disentangling the role of each is difficult since all three headwinds emerged at the same time. Most notably, the hawkish Fed pivot that raised financing costs and led to a downgrade in growth expectations (thereby possibly kicking off a headcount normalization) arrived at the same time as the release of ChatGPT. And while recent studies and company anecdotes strongly point to significant AI-related uplifts to tech worker productivity, some commentators have suggested that companies are “AI-washing” layoffs by overstating the role of AI.

In this *Global Economics Analyst*, we leverage detailed company/occupation-level employment data from Revelio Labs to quantify the impact of each of these three headwinds has had on tech sector employment.

The Overall Tech Sector Hiring Slowdown and Identification Challenge

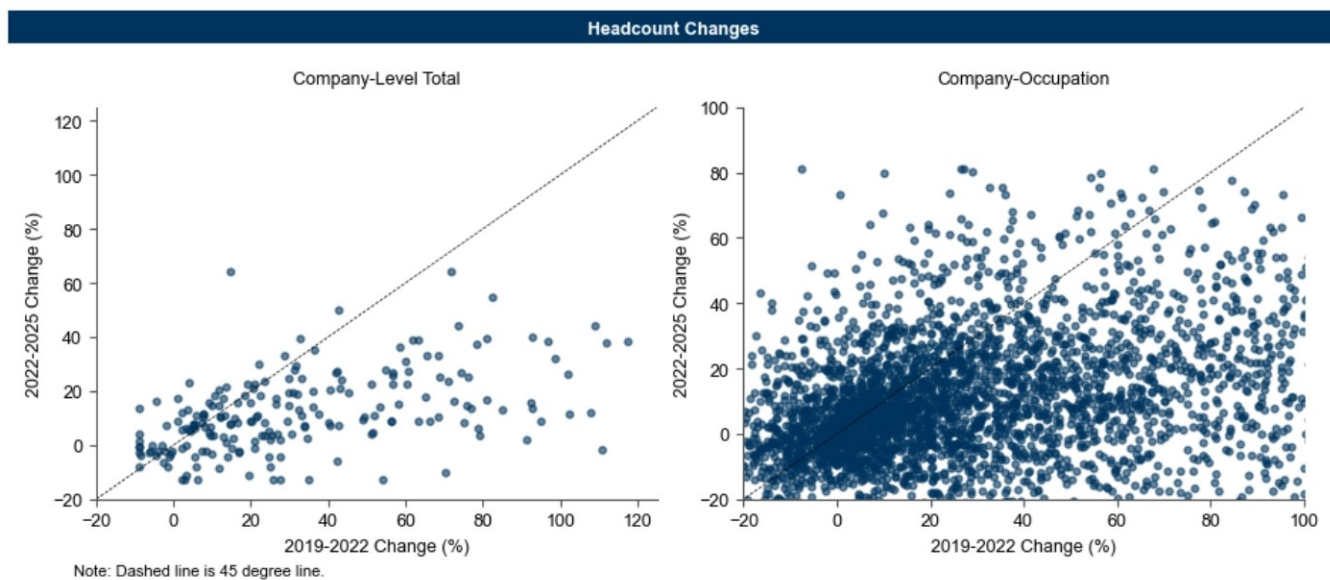
Before examining the three potential drivers of the slowdown in tech hiring, we first consider overall tech labor market trends and what questions our new data might be able (and not be able) to answer.

[Exhibit 2](#) illustrates the variation we exploit by scatter plotting 2019-2022 hiring vs. 2022-2025 hiring at both the company- and company/occupation-levels. These scatter plots illustrate several key points.

First, tech hiring slowed broadly across most companies and occupations from 2022-2025, suggesting that aggregate factors and a broad sectoral slowdown in hiring explains a large share of the labor market underperformance in recent years. Our new analysis—which leverages cross-sectional differences in company- and occupation-level hiring patterns—will not be able to conclusively identify the shock that drove this overall slowdown.

Second, both scatters illustrate that hiring patterns differed significantly across companies and particularly across occupations. Leveraging the distribution of hiring shifts across companies that were differentially exposed to higher rates and overhiring and across occupations that are differentially exposed to AI should provide useful insights into the relative importance of the different tech-sector labor market headwinds.

Exhibit 2: Company- and Company/Occupation-Level Headcount Changes Imply a Sharp Slowdown for the Sector Overall, but Substantial Variation



Source: Revelio Labs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Against this backdrop, we analyze the role of each hiring headwind separately.

Interest Rate Effects Appear Minimal

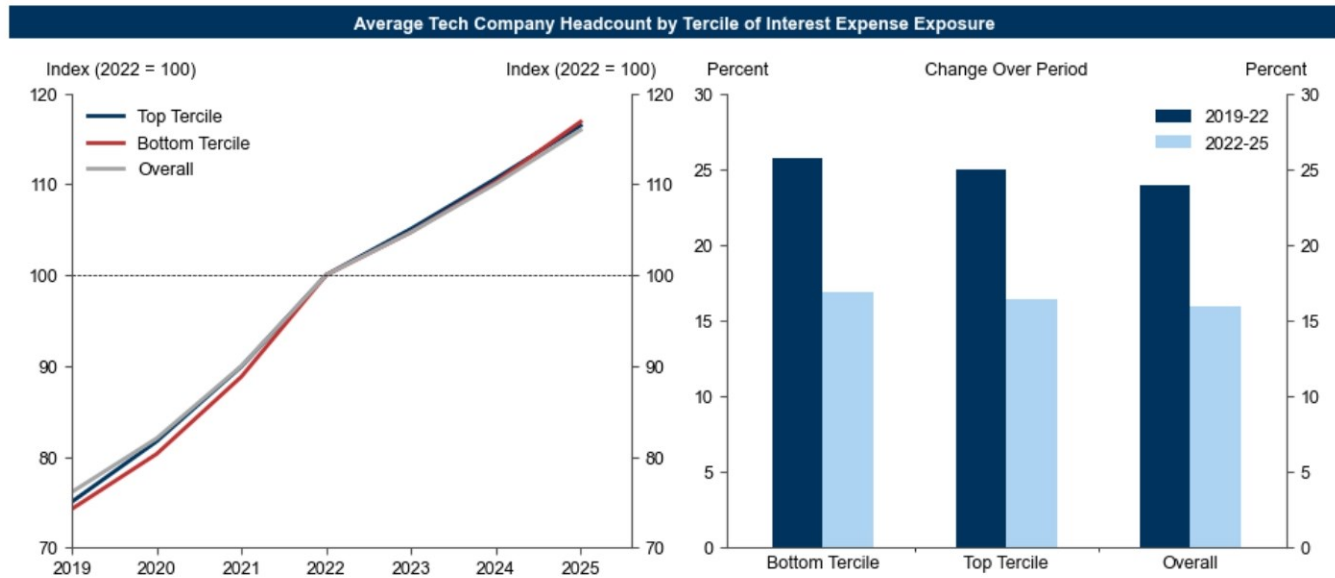
First, we find limited evidence that the tech labor market slowdown is driven by higher rates.

While the Fed's acceleration in rate hikes in late 2022 may have led to a broader downgrade in the tech sector's equity valuations, growth outlook, and hiring plans, we would expect hiring to slow more for companies that are more exposed to rate increases if they were the main driver of hiring underperformance the last several years

To test the effects of higher interest rates on tech hiring, we split our universe of public US tech companies based on changes in their interest coverage ratio (ICR, defined as annual revenue divided by annual interest expense) over the hiking cycle. We find essentially no difference in headcount evolution between the top and bottom ICR change terciles and both are essentially identical to overall tech industry trend ([Exhibit](#)

3). The lack of a relationship between interest rate exposure and tech hiring is confirmed by company-level regressions (not shown), leading us to conclude that the effect of higher rates had little impact on the tech sector's labor market underperformance.

Exhibit 3: Interest Exposure Appears to Have Had No Impact on Hiring



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

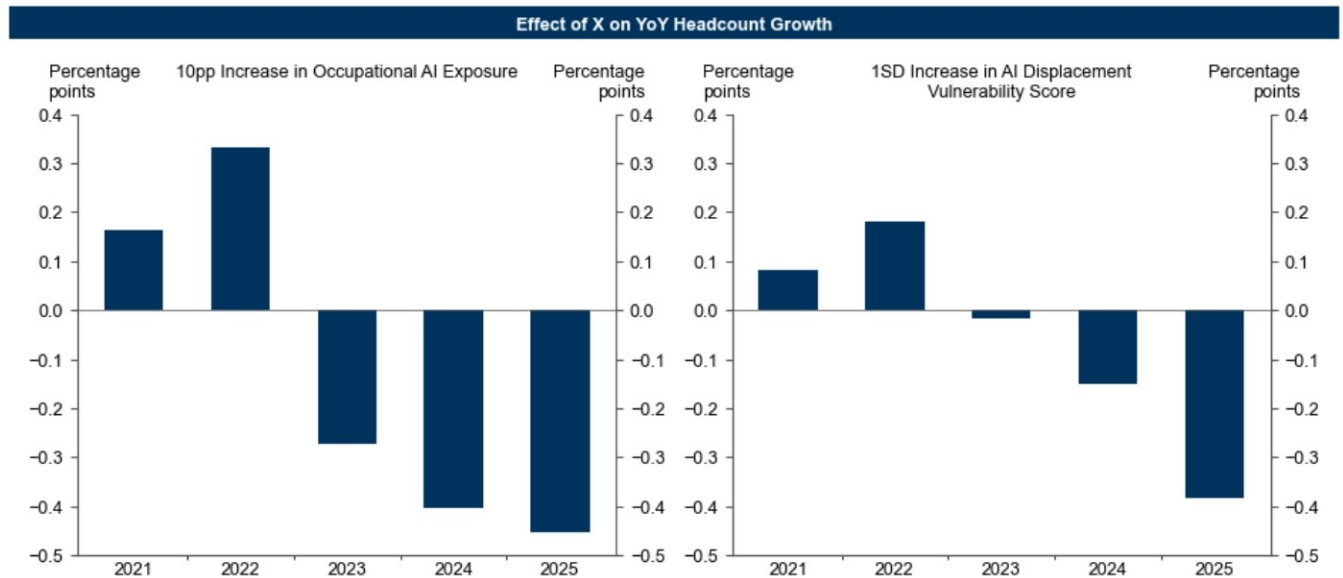
Small Overall Impact, but Some Evidence AI Layoffs Are Credible

Second, we find evidence that AI has slowed hiring, but only modestly.

To test for AI's impact, we leverage our company-occupational panel that measures headcount in over 800 distinct occupations for over 300 public tech companies from 2019-2025. We regress annual occupational headcount growth on the occupation's AI exposure—defined as the share of work tasks that are exposed to AI automation—with a time interaction to capture the evolution of the effect by year, while also controlling for company- and occupation-fixed effects.

The resulting coefficients on the AI exposure-time interaction are shown in the left chart of [Exhibit 4](#). Prior to 2023, AI exposure was positively correlated with occupational headcount growth. But by 2025, a 10pp difference in occupational AI exposure was associated with a 0.4pp drag. We repeat this analysis with the AI displacement scores we developed last year in the right chart of [Exhibit 4](#). Our results are similar, with a one standard deviation gap in vulnerability score having a positive relationship with headcount growth prior to 2022 but implying a 0.4pp drag in 2025.

Given that tech sector employees are, on average, just over 10pp more exposed to AI than the average worker in the US economy according to our scores, this estimate suggests that AI exposure can explain around ½pp of the tech sector's annual employment growth underperformance relative to economy-wide hiring.

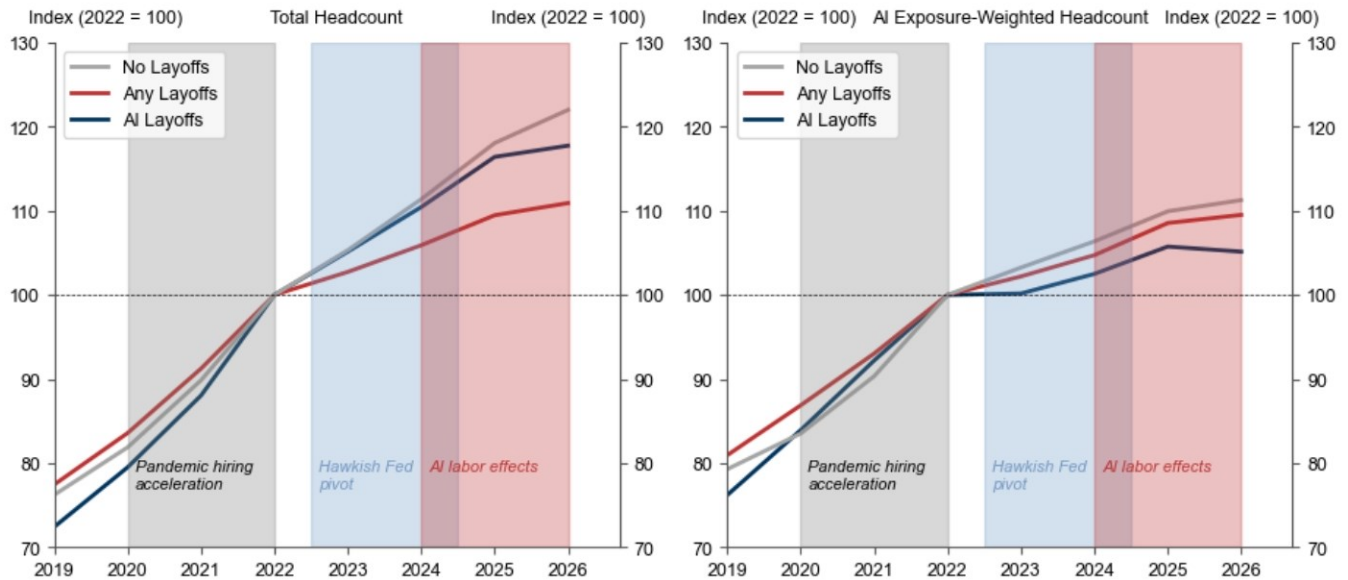
Exhibit 4: Higher AI Exposure Has Weighed Slightly on Employment Growth Since 2023

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We can also see evidence of AI's labor market effects in layoff announcements. To illustrate, we first collect data on public layoff announcements—stratified by those attributed to AI and those attributed to other factors—and merge them with our company-and occupation-level employment data. We then compare hiring trends across companies that did not announce layoffs, that announced layoffs but did not cite AI, and that attributed layoffs to AI.

The left chart of [Exhibit 5](#) unsurprisingly shows that companies that announced layoffs (whether AI-related or not) slowed hiring by more than other companies since 2022, with companies that did not cite AI efficiencies seeing the largest headcount reductions. After reweighting headcount by AI exposure, however, the right chart of [Exhibit 5](#) shows that headcount reductions have been larger for companies that attributed headcount reductions to AI. At a high level, this pattern suggests that companies are reducing headcount in a manner consistent with public announcements.

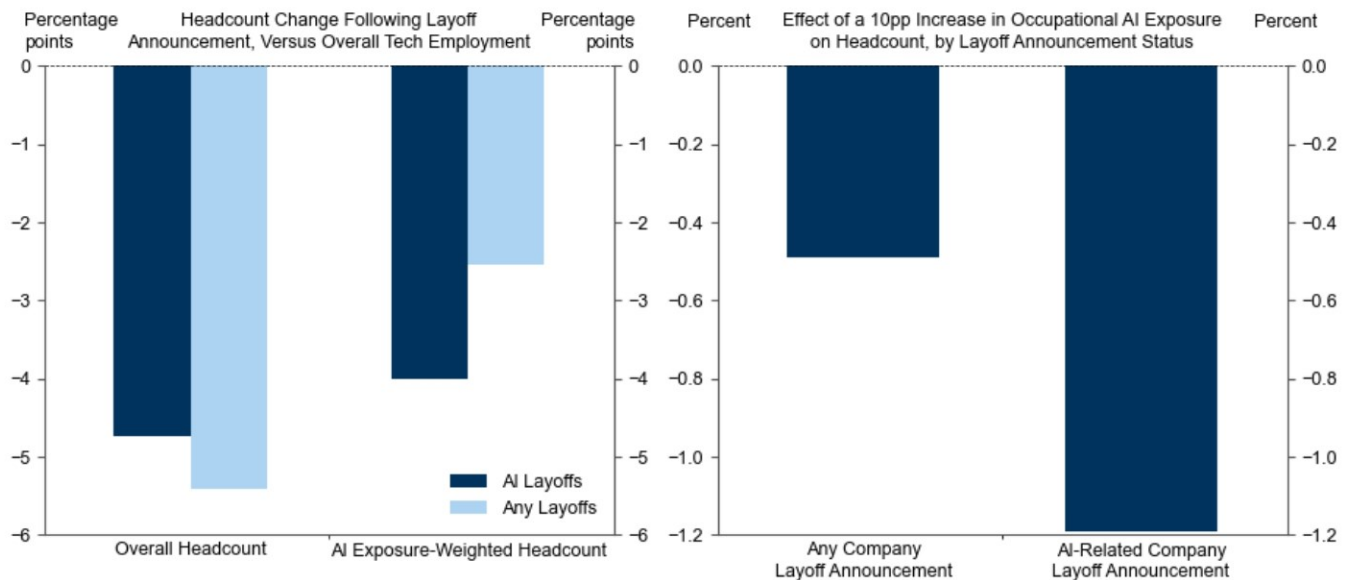
Exhibit 5: Companies That Attributed Layoffs to AI Experienced Smaller Headcount Reductions on an Overall Basis but Larger on an AI-Weighted Basis



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6 provides more rigorous statistical support for the view that AI-attributed layoff announcements are credible. After converting our panel to event time (and controlling for aggregate drivers), the left chart shows that overall headcount reductions following layoff announcements were similar across companies that did and did not cite AI as justification, but that AI-exposure weighted reductions were larger when layoffs were attributed to AI. The right chart considers the intensive margin of exposure and similarly finds that occupation-level headcount was more sensitive to AI exposure at companies that cited AI efficiencies as the reason for layoffs.

Exhibit 6: AI-Layoffs Led to Similar Overall Headcount Reductions (vs. Non-AI-Layoffs), but Larger Headcount Reductions on an AI-Weighted Basis



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Taken together, these analyses suggest that AI efficiencies have indeed weighed on tech

sector hiring over the last several years, particularly at companies that attributed headcount reductions to AI. Effects appear small, however, and the direct differences in occupational exposure can only explain about ½pp of the 5pp slowdown in annual tech employment growth since 2022.

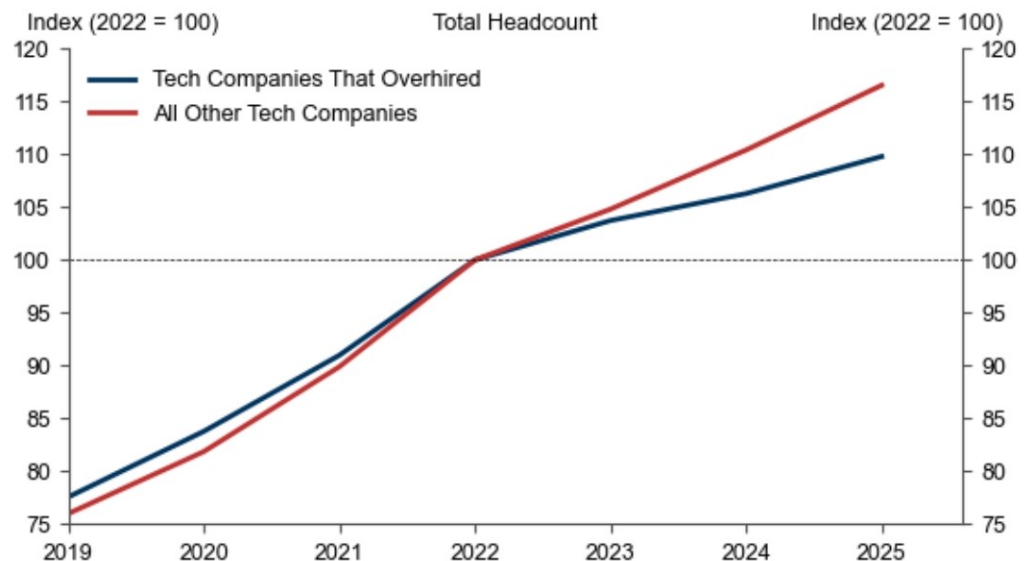
Post-Pandemic Overhiring Normalization Creates a Moderate Drag

Third, we find that pandemic-era overhiring has more meaningfully weighed on job growth in recent years.

The main challenge in testing for overhiring is that headcount is inherently tied to underlying demand, so that it is difficult to tell whether company-level hiring slowdowns reflect actual overhiring or more simply a worse growth outcome. We identify companies that overhired as those who accelerated their pace of headcount growth from 2019 to 2022 while also experiencing declining revenue per employee.¹ We then test whether this “overhiring” proxy predicts subsequent headcount growth in the post-2022 period.

Exhibit 7 provides an initial illustration of headcount trends stratified by our overhiring proxy. We find that since 2022 total headcount at companies that overhired has grown by 10%, underperforming the tech companies that did not overhire by roughly 7pp.

Exhibit 7: Companies Where Hiring Accelerated the Most from 2020-2022 Slowed More Since 2025, Possibly Due to Slower Productivity Growth



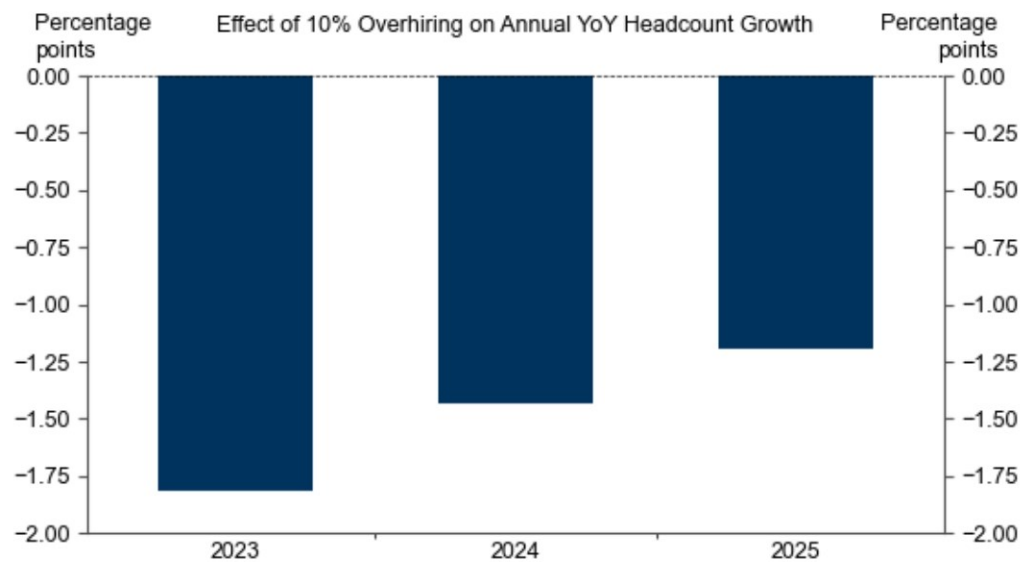
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

To statistically test the effect of a pandemic normalization in overhiring, we regress occupation-level headcount growth on the change in hiring from 2020-2022 (vs. 2018-2020) interacted with an indicator for below-average revenue per employee growth. We again include fixed company- and occupation fixed effects to control for aggregate effects. Our resulting estimate implies that a 10pp acceleration in hiring from 2020-2022 was associated with a 1-2pp underperformance in annual occupation-level

¹ Subsequent results are robust if we exclude companies that saw outright revenue declines from our sample, suggesting our results are not driven by companies that experienced a deterioration in activity.

growth from 2023–2025 ([Exhibit 8](#)). Given that sector-wide hiring accelerated by roughly 10pp according to the Revelio data, our statistical estimates suggest that up to 2pp of the slowdown in tech sector hiring can be explained by headcount normalization.

Exhibit 8: Pandemic Overhiring Was Associated with Up to a 2pp Subsequent Slowdown in Job Growth, With Effects Largest for Companies Where Productivity Growth Slowed



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Interpreting Impacts on Overall Tech Labor Market

Our cross-company and cross-occupation estimates suggest that higher interest rates had a limited impact on tech hiring, that AI exposure has slowed hiring by up to ½pp, and that headcount normalization has slowed hiring by up to 2pp. Combined, these channels can explain up to 2½pp of the slowdown in annual tech sector headcount growth, or roughly half of its 5pp underperformance (vs. long-run trend) since 2022.

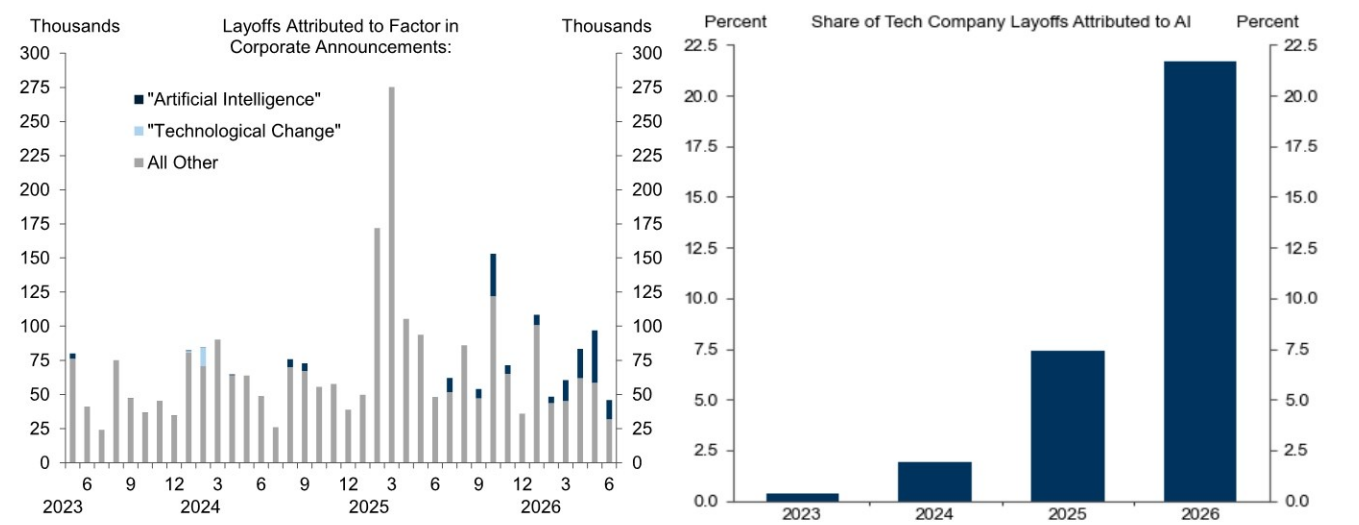
That leaves around half of the hiring underperformance unexplained by cross-company and cross-occupation variation, and therefore attributable to aggregate shocks that are common to all tech companies and workers. While it is hard to identify the source of these shocks, our estimates suggest that post-pandemic overhiring has been 3–4 times as important as AI efficiencies in explaining the slowdown in tech sector employment growth in recent years.

These relative rankings are generally consistent with tech companies' public comments on the role of AI in recent tech sector headcount reductions. The left chart of [Exhibit 9](#) shows that prior to the last few months, very few layoffs in the overall economy were attributed to AI, while the right chart shows a similar pattern for the tech sector specifically. Only in the last year has the share of AI-attributed layoffs risen above 20%.

Although AI has not played a dominant role in slowing tech hiring so far, four patterns suggest that companies are not overstating the role of AI in layoff announcements. First, tech companies that cited AI-efficiencies as a main reason for layoffs have indeed reduced headcount in AI-exposed occupations. Second, most tech companies are still not citing AI as the main driver of layoffs. Third, the share of layoff announcements that cite AI are consistent with our estimates of the relative importance of AI in recent tech

company headcount reductions. Fourth, the time patterns shown in [Exhibit 4](#) and [Exhibit 8](#)—which imply that AI-efficiencies played a small role in headcount reductions in 2023 and 2024 but a relatively more important role recently—align with the recent pickup in AI-attributed layoffs. As a result, we do not see “AI-washing” as a widespread issue.

Exhibit 9: Our Results Align with Patterns Suggesting That Most Layoff Announcements Are Not Attributable to AI, Although AI Efficiency Gains Have Contributed to Layoffs Recently



Source: Challenger, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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